ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/13: BOUNDARY, THESIS AND ANACHRONISM FIREWALL

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├─ TAMILAKAM = early Tamil cultural-geographical world, wider than modern Tamil Nadu.
├─ SANGAM AGE = modern historical convenience, not one dynasty or exact synchronized period.
├─ CORE THESIS: ecology + production + chiefship + exchange + literacy produced an uneven
│  early historic regional order.
├─ POETRY is indispensable social evidence, but not a census, revenue survey or court annal.
└─ FIREWALL: Sangam Cholas belong here; Imperial Cholas of c. ninth-thirteenth centuries
   belong to Topic 27.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/13: CHRONOLOGY AND THE SANGAM-ACADEMY LEGEND

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├─ c. first millennium BCE: regional Iron Age/megalithic burial and settlement horizons.
├─ third century BCE: Ashokan references to Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satiyaputras.
├─ late centuries BCE-early centuries CE: Tamil-Brahmi, expanding settlements and exchange.
├─ early centuries CE: dense poetic, epigraphic, numismatic and port evidence.
├─ COMPOSITION ≠ later anthologisation/redaction ≠ still later commentary.
└─ Three successive Sangams are a later learned legend, not three securely dated academies.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/13: SOURCE MATRIX AND EVIDENCE RULE

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├─ ETTUTHOKAI: short akam/puram poems, chiefs, gifts, war, work and landscape.
├─ PATTUPPATTU: longer poems on patrons, routes, towns, ports and abundance.
├─ TOLKAPPIYAM: grammar/poetics and tinai categories; composite chronology debated.
├─ EPICS/COMMENTARIES: Silappadikaram, Manimekalai and later exegesis; valuable but later.
├─ Tamil-Brahmi + megaliths + settlements + coins + ceramics + Graeco-Roman accounts.
└─ METHOD: claim → named evidence → analysis → genre/date/scale qualification.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/13: GEOGRAPHY AND THE FIVE TINAI

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├─ Vengadam/Tirupati hills form a conventional northern literary marker; the southern tip,
│  western coast, Ghats, river plains and littorals created connected ecological zones.
├─ KURINJI: hills, hunting/millet, Murugan/Seyon, union.
├─ MULLAI: pastoral woodland, cattle, Mayon, waiting.
├─ MARUTAM: wet plains, paddy, agrarian relations, Ventan.
├─ NEITAL: coast, fishing, salt, pearls, Varunan; PALAI: dry transformation, travel/raiding,
│  Korravai.
└─ TINAI = poetic-ecological grammar; never treat it as five sealed regions or a census.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 5/13: MEGALITHIC-EARLY HISTORIC RELATION AND LITERACY

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├─ Megalithic denotes archaeological burial traditions: cists, urns, dolmens, circles and
│  associated grave goods, often with iron and black-and-red ware.
├─ Burials reveal mortuary practice and differentiation, not a complete settlement map.
├─ Culture assemblage ≠ one people, language, polity, religion or migration.
├─ Tamil-Brahmi cave/pottery inscriptions record names, donors, merchants, chiefs and monks.
├─ Mangulam and Pugalur add contemporary anchors; cave beds show donative religious networks.
└─ Literacy was socially uneven; brief inscriptions do not prove mass literacy.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/13: MUVENDAR, VELIR, CENTRES AND SOURCE-QUALIFIED RULERS

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├─ CHERA: western/Kongu connections; Vanji/Karur traditions; Muchiri pepper-port context.
├─ CHOLA: Kaveri basin; Uraiyur and Puhar/Kaveripattinam.
├─ PANDYA: Madurai; Korkai pearl and Gulf of Mannar context.
├─ VELIR/local chiefs: Pari, Ori, Ay, Adiyaman in bardic memory; allegiance was negotiable.
├─ Karikala, Senguttuvan, Uthiyan Cheral and Nedunjeliyan are literary-historical names.
└─ Capital, port, lineage memory and later legend must not be collapsed into fixed borders.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/13: KINGSHIP, WAR, GIFTS, BARDS AND HEROIC MEMORY

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├─ Chiefs/kings mobilized retinues through cattle raids, warfare, tribute and route control.
├─ Booty/produce → feasts and gifts → followers and bards → fame and renewed political reach.
├─ Bards were political communicators, dependants and critics, not neutral chroniclers.
├─ Puram celebrates martial honour; vattakirutal denotes defeated royal fasting unto death.
├─ Natukal/hero stones commemorate selected deaths and values; they are not casualty registers.
└─ GIFT ECONOMY supplemented extraction and coercion; it did not replace them.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 8/13: PRODUCTION, IRRIGATION, CATTLE AND CRAFTS

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├─ Wet-rice in suitable river plains + millet/dry farming + cattle/pastoral mobility.
├─ Tanks, wells, channels and embankments enabled uneven intensification; named royal
│  attributions require source-specific proof.
├─ Fishing + salt making + pearl diving + forest products linked coast, upland and plain.
├─ Textiles, beads, iron/steel, pottery, shell and metal crafts supported inland markets.
├─ Kodumanal and related sites reveal craft-route-production intersections.
└─ Literary abundance cannot quantify yields, wages, population or universal prosperity.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/13: PORT-HINTERLAND NETWORK — KEEP THE SITES DISTINCT

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├─ PUHAR/KAVERIPATTINAM/POOMPUHAR: Chola-Kaveri outlet; literary market and east-coast port.
├─ MUCHIRI/MUZIRIS: Chera/west-coast pepper context; exact location remains debated.
├─ KORKAI: Pandya-associated pearl/fishery and shifting Gulf of Mannar littoral.
├─ ARIKAMEDU: east-coast settlement, craft and exchange site near Puducherry; not Muziris.
├─ PATTANAM: major Kerala port-site candidate for Muziris, not an epigraphically final identity.
└─ Port ≠ capital ≠ dynasty frontier; every port depended on a hinterland and middlemen.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/13: MEDITERRANEAN CONTACT — EVIDENCE AND LIMITS

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├─ EVIDENCE: amphorae, terra sigillata/related fine wares, rouletted ware, glass, coins,
│  beads, literary Yavana references, Periplus, Pliny, Ptolemy and the Muziris papyrus.
├─ Imports and coins show connection/circulation, not Roman political rule.
├─ Rouletted ware is not automatically Roman; local/regional manufacture and imitation matter.
├─ Coin hoards may represent bullion, storage, ornament, ritual or trade.
├─ Arabs, Greeks of Roman Egypt, local merchants and other intermediaries made trade multi-nodal.
└─ Evidence cannot independently calculate total volume, resident identity or economy-wide impact.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/13: SOCIETY, STATUS, WOMEN AND DEPENDENCY

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├─ Kudi/clan, lineage, occupation, wealth, ecology and political following shaped status.
├─ Brahmanas and varna vocabulary were known; four-varna conformity was not uniform.
├─ Cultivators, pastoralists, fishers, salt workers, pearl divers, artisans, merchants,
│  warriors, bards and dependants appear through unequal sources.
├─ Avvaiyar and other women poets show literary agency; women also worked in production.
├─ Kalavu/karpu are poetic-social ideals, not statistical descriptions of all marriages.
└─ Servitude, captives and dependency are evidenced cautiously; no plantation-style census.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/13: RELIGION, CULTURE, URBANISATION AND STATE FORMATION

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├─ Murugan/Seyon, Korravai, Mayon, hero/ancestor cults and protective rites remained important.
├─ Brahmanical sacrifice and deities interacted with Jain and Buddhist monks/donors.
├─ Cave donations materialize patronage; they do not prove exclusive royal conversion.
├─ Towns, craft sites, ports, writing and dues support early historic urbanisation.
├─ Debate: ranked chiefdoms ⇔ uneven early states; neither stateless tribes nor mature empires.
└─ Tamil poetry is a major cultural achievement whose historical use depends on source criticism.
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ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 13/13: TRANSFORMATION, EXAMINER TRAPS AND ANSWER SPINE

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├─ After c. third century CE, anthologisation, trade shifts and new agrarian-religious polities
│  transformed the earlier order; change was not one sudden collapse.
├─ “Kalabhra interregnum” rests on sparse/later evidence; never write a proven total dark age.
├─ Bridge forward: Pallava/Chalukya formations belong to Topic 23; Imperial Cholas to Topic 27.
├─ TRAPS: poem ≠ annal; megalith ≠ people; coin ≠ border; amphora ≠ Roman colony;
│  Pattanam ≠ conclusively Muziris; Sangam Chola ≠ Imperial Chola.
├─ ANSWER: define scope → source matrix → ecology/polity/economy/society → debate → qualification.
└─ VERDICT: early Tamilakam was connected, differentiated and increasingly institutionalized,
   but its chronology, territorial scale and social representativeness remain evidence-bounded.
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